MERIDIAN MUSEUM / 2026

Set the gala

Use ONLY the confirmed 22-guest packet file in this optional prototype. Print single-sided at 100%. Each guest has twelve pages, including a cover and detachable ballot. Put the covered packet at the assigned seat. Keep private pages facing their player.

Print the 16 discoveries and place each numbered discovery in the corresponding numbered envelope. Scatter them at the locations on the next page. Put pencils at the seats. Print the confirmed staged evidence file three times, one identical set for each table. Sort each set into ACT I: MOTIVE, ACT II: OPPORTUNITY, and ACT III: METHOD using the large act heading at the top of every sheet. Keep all nine folders locked or covered until their round. Print the host guide, name cards and animal slips once. The sixteen hunt discoveries are a separate file: print those only once for the hidden envelopes.

Before choosing the murderer, each attending guest draws a different animal, memorizes it privately and returns the slip. Collect all drawn slips, mix them, and draw one without associating it with a name. Announce that animal. Its guest reads IF MURDERER throughout; everyone else reads IF INNOCENT. Never share an animal or read branch headings aloud.

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Hide the envelopes

1	behind the television
2	inside the Bonhoeffer biography
3	under a metal chair
4	on top of a mirror
5	under a musical keyboard
6	under a trophy
7	inside a vase
8	inside a cupboard
9	behind a painting
10	on top of a map of Barcelona
11	behind red curtains
12	near a green lamp
13	above the garage door
14	inside a Bible
15	behind a blue cushion
16	inside the freezer

Introductions and hunt

Invite every guest to read their introduction box on page 2. Allow mingling before the murder announcement.

Announce that Grant Larceny has died at the gala after his private toast. Invite players to turn to their Hunt for Clues page. Set aside about 15 minutes for finding envelopes; the guest finding the most wins a prize. Guests bring envelopes to their seats.

Have the finders open and read all 16 discoveries aloud. Display each discovery at the Evidence Table. Retrieve and read any missed envelope so the case never depends on finding every hiding place.

Three investigation acts

Before Act I: unlock the three ACT I: MOTIVE folders and distribute one to each table. Read the board secretary's notice. Then announce ACT I: MOTIVE. Players use pages 5–6.

Before Act II: unlock the three ACT II: OPPORTUNITY folders and distribute one to each table. Read the service manager's account and initial laboratory findings. Then announce ACT II: OPPORTUNITY. Players use pages 7–8.

Before Act III: unlock the three ACT III: METHOD folders and distribute one to each table. Read all records, retained-view captions and the untrimmed press interview in this section. Allow time for all tables to review the comparisons before the readings. Then announce ACT III: METHOD. Players use pages 9–10.

In each act, invite a guest to choose an unheard attending character by name and ask their printed question from the question page. The named guest reads their own branch and chooses the next unheard guest. Tick that name on the fresh per-act checklist. Every attending guest answers once. If the chain stalls or a completed name is chosen, nominate an unheard guest. When all 22 have answered, close the act. Let discussion happen between rounds while keeping later pages private.

Accusations and Coming Clean

After Act III, allow discussion and ask everyone to detach page 11, accuse one attending guest, and hand in the ballot. Count all ballots before revealing anything.

Tally every attending character, including zero votes. Rank the original top three by total; break ties alphabetically by full character name. Announce ALL THREE names together. Only named INNOCENT guests read Coming Clean now, one at a time in any order. The murderer waits even if named. Do not replace a waiting murderer with the fourth-ranked innocent.

When the named innocents finish, ALWAYS call the selected animal: its guest stands and reads IF MURDERER LAST, whether or not named in the top three. This gives three speeches if the murderer is named, four otherwise. Escaped Justice depends on the ORIGINAL locked top-three tally. Award the accusation, acting, costume and scavenger prizes.

Suggested pacing: 20 minutes arrival and introductions, 15 minutes hunt, 15–20 minutes per act, 10 minutes accusations, 15 minutes finale. Adjust for conversation and food service; finish all essential evidence before voting.